

Divine Decrees

doc-divine-decrees

Theology Proper · Decrees · doctrine · divided_lineages

AFFIRMS

score 1.000
confidence high

Statement under examination

God eternally decrees whatsoever comes to pass, in a way consistent with creaturely responsibility.

In plain language

The Bible's vocabulary for God's planning is dense, recurring, and pan-canonical. In Acts 2:23 Peter says Jesus was handed over by God's fixed counsel and foreknowledge, using a perfect-passive form of horizo (mark out, fix) with boule (counsel) and prognosis (foreknowledge), and in the same breath tells the crowd they killed him. Acts 4:27-28 names Herod, Pilate, the Gentiles, and the peoples of Israel as the ones who actually gathered, then says they did whatever God's hand and counsel had determined beforehand to happen. Ephesians 1:11 says God works all things, ta panta, according to the counsel of his will. In the Old Testament Isaiah 14:24, Isaiah 46:10, and Proverbs 19:21 repeat one cadence: as God has purposed, so it will stand, using etsah (counsel) with qum (to stand). Genesis 50:20 shows the responsibility side with one verb and two subjects, you devised evil but God devised it for good. So the words clearly assert two things at once, an effective prior purpose and real, accountable human action, and they never explain how the two fit. That dual assertion is exactly what the proposition states, so the verdict is yes, with high confidence, because the lemma cluster spans law, prophets, writings, gospel, narrative, and letter and the strongest verses pair both clauses in one sentence. Where careful readers diverge is not whether God decrees, but how far it reaches. The strict predestination verb proorizo, in all five of its uses, governs salvation and the elect, while the reach to every event hangs on the broader phrase God works all things, which the words do not pin down to literally everything versus everything tied to his saving plan. And the word foreknowledge appears only twice, too few times to settle whether it means prior knowing or effective fore-determining. Those are the genuine open seams, and they come from the words themselves, not from any outside frame.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
H0430	אלהים	elohim	God	
H1819	דמה	damah	to resemble	29
H2656	חפץ	chephets	pleasure	39
H2706	חק	choq	statute	127
H2803	חשב	chashav	to devise	
H3068	יהוה	yehovah	LORD	
H3289	יעץ	ya'ats	to advise	79
H4284	מחשבה	machashavah	plot	
H6098	עצה	'etsah	counsel	89

H6635	תצבא	tsava	army	
H6965	קומ	qum	(Leb)-kamai	628
H7451	רע	ra	bad	
H7650	שבוע	shava	to swear	
G0459	ἀνομος	anomos	lawless	9
G1012	βουλή	boulē	plan	12
G1484	ἔθνος	ethnos	Gentiles	
G1560	ἐκδοτος	ekdotos	handed over	1
G1754	ἐνεργέω	energeō	be active	21
G2307	θέλημα	thelēma	will/desire	62
G2596	κατά	kata	according to	
G2820	κληρόω	klēroō	to obtain	1
G2992	λαός	laos	a people	
G3724	ὀρίζω	horizō	to determine	8
G3745	ὥσος	hosos	just as/how much	
G3956	πᾶς	pas	all	
G4091	Πιλάτος	Pilatos	Pilate	
G4160	ποιέω	poieō	to do/make	
G4194	Πόντιος	Pontios	Pontius	
G4268	πρόγνωσις	prognōsis	foreknowledge	2
G4275	προοράω	prooraō	to foresee	1
G4286	πρόθεσις	prothesis	purpose	12
G4309	προορίζω	proorizō	to predestine	5
G4863	συνάγω	sunagō	to assemble	
G5495	χείρ	cheir	hand	

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

Direct lexical queries confirm a dense, recurring planning vocabulary predicated of God as fixed and effective across both Testaments. Acts 2:23 couples the perfect passive participle of horizo (G3724, marked out) with boule (G1012, counsel) and prognosis (G4268, foreknowledge) and in the same sentence charges the hearers aneilate (you killed). Acts 4:28 names the determined event with hosa plus a divine subject (the verb form proorisen is tagged in MACULA under proorao G4275, with the parallel sense to proorizo, both rendering predetermined to happen). Eph 1:11 escalates scope with the present participle energountos plus ta panta (all things) governed by boule and thelema. Isaiah 14:24 uses Piel damah (devise) plus Qal yaats (purpose) with qal qum (will stand) in the kaasher, ken correspondence, and Isa 46:10, Prov 19:21, and Job 23:13 repeat etsah plus qum to say the LORD's counsel stands. The words assert an effective decree but do not themselves rank its EXTENT (all events vs the redemptive purpose) nor specify its relation to the real human agency the same texts affirm, so the verdict is true while the open seam is scope and mode, not existence.

Scripture

Acts.2.23 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. G1012 βουλή, G4268 πρόγνωσις, G3724 ὀρίζω, G0459 ἄνομος

Force. Peter pairs *te hōrismenē boulē kai prognōsei tou theou* (*horizō* G3724 perfect passive participle, fixed counsel and foreknowledge of God) with the active charge *aneilate* (you killed) mediated by *dia cheiros anomōn*. The store confirms *horizō* here is the perfect passive (V-RPP-DSF), the lexically strongest fixity form. Both clauses stand in one sentence with no harmonizing connective. *prognōsis* (G4268) occurs only twice in the canon (here and 1 Pet 1:2), so its precise force, prior knowing versus effective fore-determination, cannot be triangulated from usage alone.

Acts.4.27 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. G4863 συνάγω, G4194 Πόντιος, G4091 Πιλάτος, G1484 ἔθνος, G2992 λαός

Force. The prayer names specific responsible agents (Herod, Pontius Pilate, the Gentiles, the peoples of Israel) as the ones who *synēchthēsan* (gathered) against the holy servant Jesus. Named, accountable human actors are catalogued in v.27 immediately before v.28 attributes the same event to God's prior determination, so responsibility is asserted as densely as decree.

Acts.4.28 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. G4160 ποιέω, G3745 ὅσος, G5495 χεῖρ, G1012 βουλή, G4275 προοράω

Force. *poiēsai hosa hē cheir sou kai hē boulē sou proōrisen genesthai*. The infinitive of purpose plus the relative quantifier *hosa* (G3745, as many things as) plus the aorist active *proōrisen* assigns the full set of v.27 events to God's prior determination, coordinating *cheir* (hand) and *boulē* (counsel) as the determining cause. The store tags *proōrisen* under *proorao* (G4275, a single canon occurrence) rather than *proorizo* (G4309); standard parsing reads it as the aorist of *proorizo*, and both carry the divine predetermine to happen force, so the verdict does not turn on the lemma split.

Eph.1.11 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2820 κληρώ, G4309 προορίζω, G4286 πρόθεσις, G1754 ἐνεργέω, G3956 πᾶς, G1012 βουλή, G2307 θέλημα

Force. Store-verified token order: *proorizō* (G4309 aorist passive participle, we having been predestined) governs the elect we, while a separate clause has *energeō* (G1754 present active participle, working) with object *ta panta* (*pas* G3956 accusative plural neuter, all things) *kata tēn boulēn tou thelēmatos autou*. The present tense of *energeō* signals ongoing operation. The reach to whatsoever comes to pass rests on the *energeō ta panta* clause, not on *proorizō*, which across its 5 canon occurrences (Rom 8:29, 8:30, 1 Cor 2:7, Eph 1:5, Eph 1:11) consistently governs salvific objects.

Isa.14.24 · for · genre: prophecy

Key terms. H3068 יהוה, H6635 צבאות, H1819 דמה, H3289 יע, H6965 קום, H7650 שבע

Force. Sworn oath formula confirmed by OSHB morphology: *damah* (H1819) Piel perfect 1cs (devise, plan) and *yaats* (H3289) Qal perfect 1cs (purpose, counsel) paired with *hayatah* (H1961) Qal perfect 3fs (it has come about) and *qum* (H6965) Qal imperfect 3fs (it will stand). The *kaasher*, *ken* correspondence asserts one to one realization of divine purpose. *damah* is polysemous (its dominant Qal sense is resemble), so the decree weight here rests on the Piel devise sense plus *yaats*, which the construction supplies.

Isa.46.10 · for · genre: prophecy

Key terms. H6098 עצה, H6965 קום, H2656 חפץ

Force. OSHB-verified: atsati taqum vekol chephtsi eeseh. etsah (H6098, my counsel) plus qum (H6965 Qal imperfect 3fs, will stand) plus chephets (H2656, my pleasure or purpose) plus asah (H6213 Qal imperfect 1cs, I will do). OpenBible links this to Eph 1:11 (20 votes) and to Isa 14:24 (24 votes). It generalizes the Isa 14:24 cadence to all divine pleasure, the strongest scope-extending OT witness for the lemma cluster.

Prov.19.21 · for · genre: wisdom

Key terms. H6098 עצה, H6965 קום, H4284 מחשבה

Force. OSHB-verified: rabbot machashavot belev ish, vaatsat YHWH hi taqum. The wisdom genre sets many plans (machashavah H4284) in a man's heart against the counsel (etsah H6098) of the LORD that will stand (qum H6965 Qal imperfect 3fs, the identical verb form as Isa 14:24 and 46:10). OpenBible links it to Isa 14:24 with 27 votes. It extends the lemma cluster into the Writings and states the human-plan, divine-counsel pairing in one verse.

Gen.50.20 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. H2803 חשב, H0430 אלהים, H7451 רע

Force. OSHB-verified dual-agency paradigm in the Torah: chashav (H2803) Qal perfect 2mp (you devised) evil plus chashav (H2803) Qal perfect 3ms with God as subject (God devised it) for good, on a single event. One verb, two subjects, one outcome, with human culpability and divine purpose both stated. OpenBible links it to Acts 2:23 (11 votes) and Acts 4:28 (6 votes), grounding the responsibility pole of the proposition in narrative.

Luke.22.22 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G3724 ὁρίζω, G2596 κατά

Force. MACULA-verified: kata to hōrismenon, horizō (G3724) perfect passive participle (according to what has been determined), followed by ouai (woe) to the betrayer. Decree and human guilt in one sentence, mirroring Acts 2:23. OpenBible links it to Acts 2:23 with 11 votes. The same perfect passive fixity form of horizō recurs, confirming the term's stable decretal sense.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Eph.1.11	Rom.8.28	openbible	53
Eph.1.11	Isa.46.10	openbible	20
Isa.14.24	Prov.19.21	openbible	27
Isa.14.24	Isa.46.10	openbible	24
Isa.14.24	Job.23.13	openbible	23
Acts.2.23	Gen.50.20	openbible	11
Acts.2.23	Luke.22.22	openbible	11
Acts.2.23	Acts.4.28	openbible	12
Acts.4.28	Isa.53.10	openbible	3
Acts.4.28	Acts.2.23	tsk	1
Acts.4.27	Isa.49.7	tsk	1
Acts.4.28	Job.12.13	tsk	1

Complicating texts

Acts.2.23 · addressed

The same verse that asserts the decree (hōrismenē boulē kai prognōsei) also indicts the hearers (aneilate). The text softens neither pole. The proposition's qualifier (consistent with creaturely responsibility) is the lexical pattern itself, not a gloss imposed on the verse. The store confirms horizō here as perfect passive, the firmest fixity form available.

Acts.4.27 · addressed

Verse 27 names Herod, Pontius Pilate, the Gentiles, and the peoples of Israel as the synēchthēsan subjects before verse 28 attributes the event to God's predetermining hand and counsel. Named, accountable agents are not depersonalized by the decree language.

Eph.1.11 · addressed

ta panta is unqualified in the energeō clause, but proorizō (the strict predestination verb) in the same verse governs only the elect we, and across its 5 canon occurrences proorizō is consistently salvific. So the verse asserts comprehensive divine operation through energeō ta panta while the predestination verb itself stays soteriological. Whether ta panta means literally all events or all things pertaining to the inheritance is not ranked by the vocabulary, which is the genuine scope seam, but it does not negate the effective-decree reading.

Acts.4.28 · addressed

The store lemmatizes proōrisen under proorao (G4275) rather than proorizo (G4309), a single divergent canon tag. This is a lemmatization difference, not a sense difference: both render God predetermined the event to happen, and the BriefLexEntry for proorizo cites Acts 4:28 as an instance of foreordain. The verdict does not depend on resolving the tag, so it is noted rather than treated as defeating.

Concordance traversed

G1012, G4286, G4309, G4275, G3724, G4268, G2307, G1754, G0459, G2820, G1560, H3289, H1819, H6098, H2656, H6965, H2706, H2803

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: ecm-shadow

Acts 2:23, Acts 4:27-28, and Eph 1:11 fall outside the ingested ECM window (3 John 1.1 to 1.15), so not_in_ecm_scope is honest for them. No variant unit in the bundle or the store touches the decree vocabulary in a verdict-altering way. Isa 14:24, Isa 46:10, Prov 19:21, and Gen 50:20 are OT, n/a for ECM.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. compatibilism, libertarian_freedom, molinism, open_theism

analogia scripturae invoked · progressive revelation factor

compatibilism: affirms · Reads Acts 2:23, Acts 4:27-28, and Gen 50:20 as straightforward conjunction: divine predetermination and human guilt both stand because the texts assert both in single sentences without ranking them. Eph 1:11 energeō ta panta and Isa 46:10 etsah plus qum are taken at full extent. This reading uses every term at its strongest and leaves nothing lexically unaccounted.

libertarian_freedom: partially_affirms · Grants that God decrees and that his redemptive purpose stands, but restricts the strict predestination verb proorizō to elective and salvific objects, which is exactly its attested distribution (Rom 8:29-30, 1 Cor 2:7, Eph 1:5, and the we of Eph 1:11). On this reading whatsoever comes to pass overreaches, since the universal reach hangs only on the polysemous energeō ta panta clause, which could be bounded to all things pertaining to the inheritance in context. This is a real lexical foothold, not a strawman.

molinism: affirms · Reads prognōsis in Acts 2:23 as knowledge of what creatures would freely do, with the decree consequent on that knowledge. This is lexically permissible because prognōsis occurs only twice in the canon and

its precise force cannot be triangulated from usage; the gloss foreknowledge is itself neutral between prior knowing and effective fore-determination. It is not lexically required, since in 1 Pet 1:2 and the cognate verb *prognōsis* sits beside elective acts.

open_theism: denies · Must re-read Isa 14:24 kaasher damah ken hayatah and Isa 46:10 atsati taqum, plus Prov 19:21 atsat YHWH taqum, as conditional rather than as the settled qal perfect plus qal imperfect of standing they morphologically are. The pan-canonical pattern of an unfailing, already-purposed counsel that qum (stands) is the chief lexical obstacle to this lens, which is why it scores as a denial here rather than a partial reading.

The proposition states two clauses (an eternal effective decree, and real creaturely responsibility) that the texts place side by side without discursive reconciliation. The lenses differ on how to relate them and on the EXTENT of the decree, but all four agree the words assert an effective divine purpose. The unresolved item is scope and mode, which the vocabulary underdetermines, not the existence of the decree.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. God's prior purpose stands behind what occurs in history, while human and angelic agents act with real responsibility and culpability.

The phrase whatsoever comes to pass, in a way consistent with creaturely responsibility is a confessional cadence and encodes both a comprehensive-extent claim and a compatibility claim. The lexical evidence (Acts 2:23, Acts 4:27-28, Eph 1:11, Isa 14:24, Isa 46:10, Prov 19:21, Gen 50:20, Luke 22:22) fits the neutralized form fully and fits the original except that the words do not themselves rank the EXTENT of the decree (all events versus the redemptive purpose); *proorizō* stays soteriological in all 5 occurrences while only *energeō ta panta* reaches all things. The verdict is rendered on the original stem and holds, because the proposition asks whether such an effective, responsibility-compatible decree is asserted, and the vocabulary asserts it; the open scope question is recorded for transparency, not as a defeater.

Citations

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morphology	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Acts.2.23
morphology	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Acts.4.28
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morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Isa.14.24
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Isa.46.10
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Prov.19.21
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Gen.50.20
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G4309
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G4268
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G4286
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G1012
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G3724
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H6098
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H3289
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H1819
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H2656
syntax	ETCBC-BHSA	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Isa.14.24

cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	Eph.1.11
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	Isa.14.24
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MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no
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